

Deep Dive: Preventing Burnout: Know the Signs

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There is no “one thing” or magic tip for avoiding burnout, despite what all the articles and tabloids may tell you. There aren’t any shortcuts. You *have* to prevent it holistically. There are two basic parts to burnout: physical and mental, and both are important.

We’ve already talked a little about the mental – slowing down and taking breaks during the day. Having strategies to “de-stress” like mindfulness or meditation, knowing what you need specifically at the end of a day or in any given work week to recharge. Knowing how to distance yourself from issues at work and setting boundaries. But the physical is just as important as the mental.

Having a career is a lot of stress – it doesn’t matter which industry you’re in, and you have to make sure your body is set up appropriately to handle it. This includes three basic areas of preventative care:

First exercise – one of the most common effects of stress on our body can be mitigated by exercise. Psychologists will tell you when you’re experiencing stress, one of the best things you can do is to get moving -- even if it’s just 20-30 min a day. When your body is wound up, it produces a lot of stress hormones and adrenaline that have nowhere to go unless you release it.

The key is finding the type of exercise that fits the best in your schedule, that is the most fun for you. For some people it’s walking, for some people it may be the gym. Others take a weekly class or enjoy yoga – whatever it is, find what works for you so you can keep your body in shape to go the long haul.

Next is sleep – Making sure you’re getting 7-8 hours of sleep each night and not skipping on shuteye, in addition to getting *quality* sleep. Tossing and turning till 11:30 pm and waking up at 5:00 am is not quality sleep!

Finally, you know what I’m going to say – eating habits. You don’t have to exist on carrot sticks and tofu, but you really want to be mindful of what you’re putting into your body. How much fast food, how much processed food, what your first meal of the day looks like, right down to the shakes and supplements you take.

These three things work together to keep your body functioning at a healthy, optimal level to handle the amount of stress you're going to put on it.

So the third step to avoid burnout is to know the signs. Let's say you're doing all of the above, but you still feel off, like something isn't right. It's *going* to happen.

Many people, sometimes the best and brightest of us – or the toughest – blow right past this one and wind up driving themselves into a wall. Many people see the signs, but they feel trapped and just don't know what to do. So, what are some specific signs you may be experiencing burnout?

The first is usually fatigue. A nagging, chronic fatigue that doesn't go away with rest. When you experience chronic fatigue it's your body's way of telling you that something is off. Something in your life is causing more fatigue than your body can handle, and work is often times the culprit. The extreme version of this is full-blown insomnia, finding it hard to wind down or go to sleep because your body is so wound up or jacked up during the day.

You might find yourself overly dependent on stimulants like caffeine, energy drinks or tea just to make it through the day. Having 2-3 cups of coffee a day doesn't always mean you're burnt out, but you want to be careful about how much you're "overriding" your body's natural responses and rhythms with chemicals.

Next, you may have difficulty concentrating, you feel overwhelmed, like it's hard to stay on top of all the details. Like you've been behind – for months – and you can't seem to catch up. You may have increased irritability and find yourself on a shorter fuse than normal. Many psychologists point to an increase in cynicism and unplugging yourself from your job – a lack of enthusiasm about the things you used to care about. You may feel like you're just "mailing it in." There's a lack of motivation or you feel overwhelmed. The extreme version of this, of course, is depression and isolation, where you physically withdraw to protect yourself from the burnout or stress.

And the truth is, there is a wide variety of health symptoms that accompany burnout – we don't have time to list them all here, but these are just a few: headaches, unexplained stomach issues, non-cardiac chest pain, muscle pain, blood sugar issues or getting sick every other month – all this plays into how your body feels and how it's trying to handle the stress. Remember the old saying, "The body keeps the score."

OK, so how do we avoid getting there? If we know some of the signs, how can we avoid getting to the point where burnout controls our lives or worse, causes you to have to quit a job you love?

It comes down to two main things -- Read the writing on the wall, and always have a backup plan.

First, once you spot the signs of burnout and you've done all you can to address the burnout in the role you're in, you've got to "read the writing on the wall." You've got to see things for what they are. Are they going to get better? Not just wishes and hopes -- have they *gotten* any better in the last year or two? Do you have the power to affect the change in this situation, or is it in the hands of another person?

It goes without saying that *before* you read the writing on the wall, it may mean an honest conversation with your employer about what's going on and seeing about any adjustments that can be made to the situation you're in. How many times have you seen an otherwise great team member who was struggling with burnout, and they didn't say anything until they just gave up and crashed? That's *not* what we're saying here. The writing may not be "on the wall" yet. You don't want to hit the eject button too early.

Many times, there's adjustments that can be made before it gets to that point, and sometimes you don't know what they are until you speak up. There may be things you can delegate, even if it requires more training for a team member. It may mean setting more realistic goals, or re-setting expectations with your team. You may need to set boundaries at work or around certain projects. All of these things can help.

But let's say that you've done these things, and you still find yourself at a dead end. Or maybe there's something that just can't be changed about the situation you're in. Reading the writing on the wall and not being afraid to do so -- being honest about where you are -- puts the power back in YOUR hands to be able to honestly assess the situation and make any changes you need to make. The mistake most people make is letting things go too far and they don't read the writing on the wall until they crash or hit empty, and they don't wind up making the best decision about what comes next. At that point things usually can't be saved and it's "any port in a storm."

When your entire world, your livelihood, your worth, isn't attached to whatever drama or stress may be going on at the moment, you can see things a lot clearer.

Early on in my career, I was a mom, had my first big promotion, and I couldn't handle it all. I felt guilty not being there for my child and my husband. I wanted to show the world that I was a rockstar professional, that I can handle anything that was thrown my way, but I couldn't. So, I ended up seeking external help from a mentor. Please make sure you know the signs as stated. I avoided the signs, and I wish I would've caught it much sooner, but I did reach out for help. Reaching out for help can look like many things depending on what you need at the moment. Regardless, just stop, take a deep breath. Don't be so hard on

yourself. Know that you can't always do it all for everyone, and don't let yourself get to burnout. Remember, be in it for the long haul.

We want you to be the best version of *you* at work. And that requires being able to handle burnout like a boss.